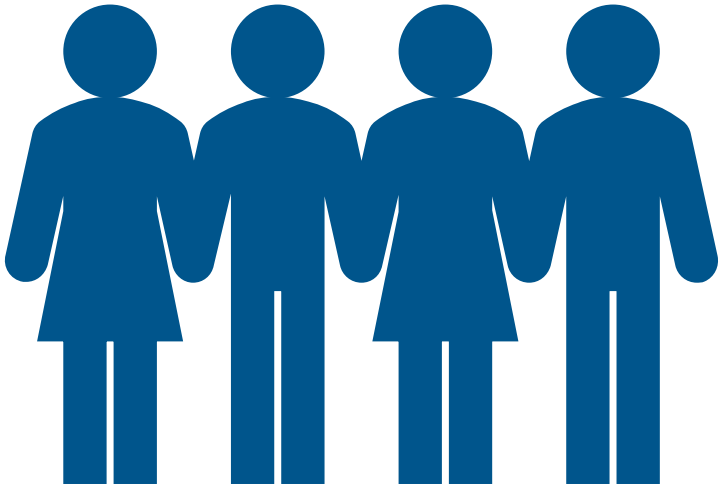
Rise Up Cambridge Final Evaluation

Human Services Committee

April 8, 2026

mdrc
BUILDING KNOWLEDGE TO IMPROVE SOCIAL POLICY



Acknowledgements

- AidKit
- Cambridge Community Foundation
- Cambridge Economic Opportunity Committee
- City of Cambridge
- Community Researchers
- Rise Up Cambridge Participants
- Research Advisory Council

Overview

1. About MDRC
2. Background
3. Research Design
4. Findings
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About MDRC



- **Learn what works** to improve policy, practice, and the well-being of people in low-income communities.
- Build **learning agendas** that advance the goals of programs, organizations, and systems.
- Provide **technical assistance** to practitioners, policymakers, and other decision-makers.

Research on Short-Term Cash Assistance

Short-term interventions can lead to positive, but modest, short-term effects

- Short-term cash payments effectively solve some, but not all, economic challenges
- No large-scale economic changes
- Reduced food insecurity and mental distress
- Limited evidence of effects on work
- Numerous U.S. evaluations, varied study designs and program features

Rise Up Cambridge

Rise Up Cambridge built on Cambridge RISE and expanded eligibility to additional families

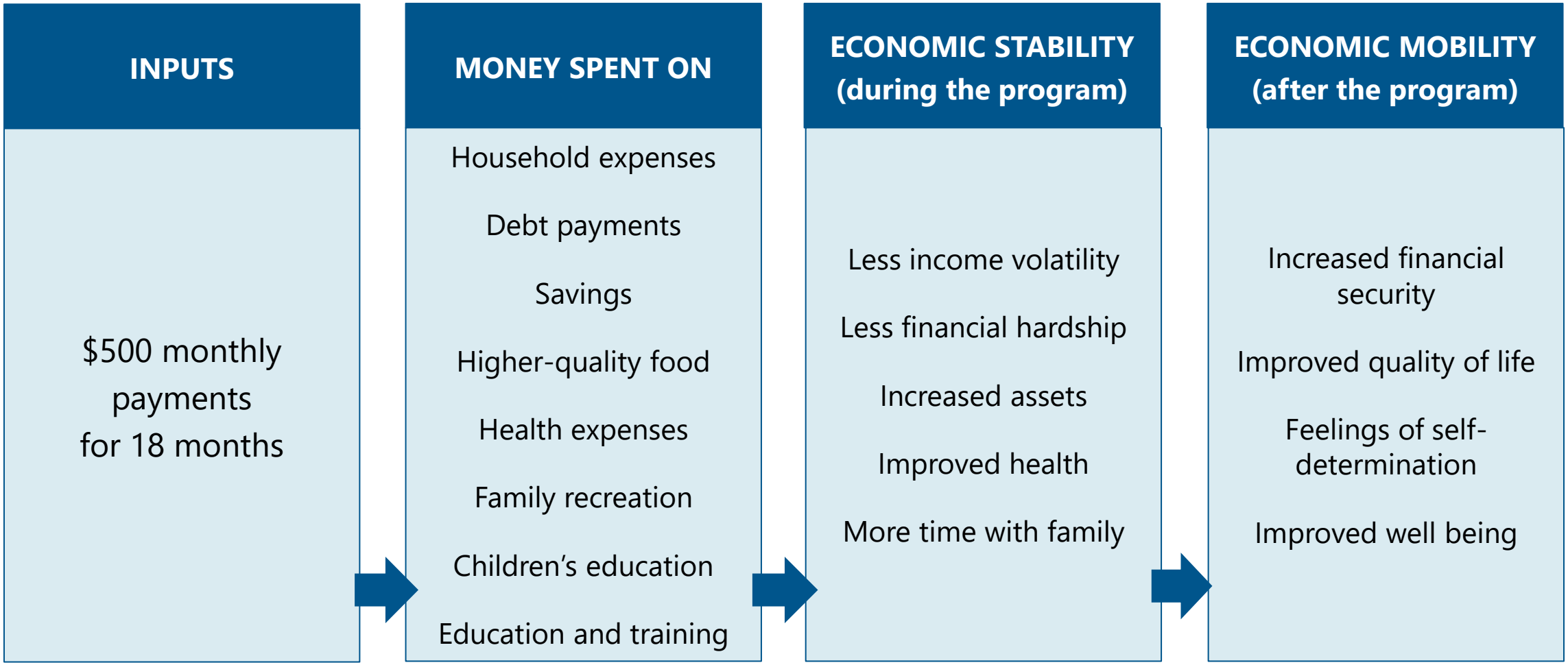


Households with children at or under 21 years of age, earning up to 250 percent of the Federal Poverty Level

First payments disbursed between June and August 2023. Final payments disbursed between December 2024 and February 2025.

Households received $500 per month for 18 months ($9,000 total).

Conceptual Framework



Research Questions

- What are households' perspectives on the program and cash payments?
- What outcomes did the Rise Up program generate for families?
- How did families with different characteristics and circumstances benefit from and experience the program?
- How is the program implemented and what is the policy context around this program in Cambridge?

Research Design

A longitudinal mixed-method design combining interviews, focus groups, surveys, and storytelling. Data collected at multiple points to examine changes in Rise Up families' experiences and circumstances over time.

- **Outcomes** - Examine key indicators at study enrollment, one, and two years later
- **Implementation** - Examine Rise Up operations, participant experiences, contributions to observed outcomes
- **Comparative Analysis** - Examine differences based on household income and racial/ethnic identity

Research Design

Strengths

- Using multiple data sources allows triangulation; verification across multiple data sources and methods
- Comparative approach shows outcomes and experiences of families with different characteristics
- Study period includes first 6 months after payments
- Centers racial equity and community engagement

Limitations

- Cannot make causal claims due to absence of a comparison group
- Quantitative survey data may not represent true early snapshot as responses drew on participant recollection
- Qualitative findings are not generalizable given relatively smaller number

EVALUATION FINDINGS

Findings At A Glance

Participants were grateful for Rise Up, its features, and the support it provided. Contributed to reduced stress, a sense of empowerment, and more time with family.

Families experienced meaningful financial relief during the program and incremental progress that may contribute to future economic mobility, but some hardships remained.

Higher income families fare better. Some differences were observed across racial or ethnic groups. However, differences may reflect prior circumstances

Extensive outreach and an online application made citywide reach possible. Rise Up did not count as income; participants maintained their other benefits.

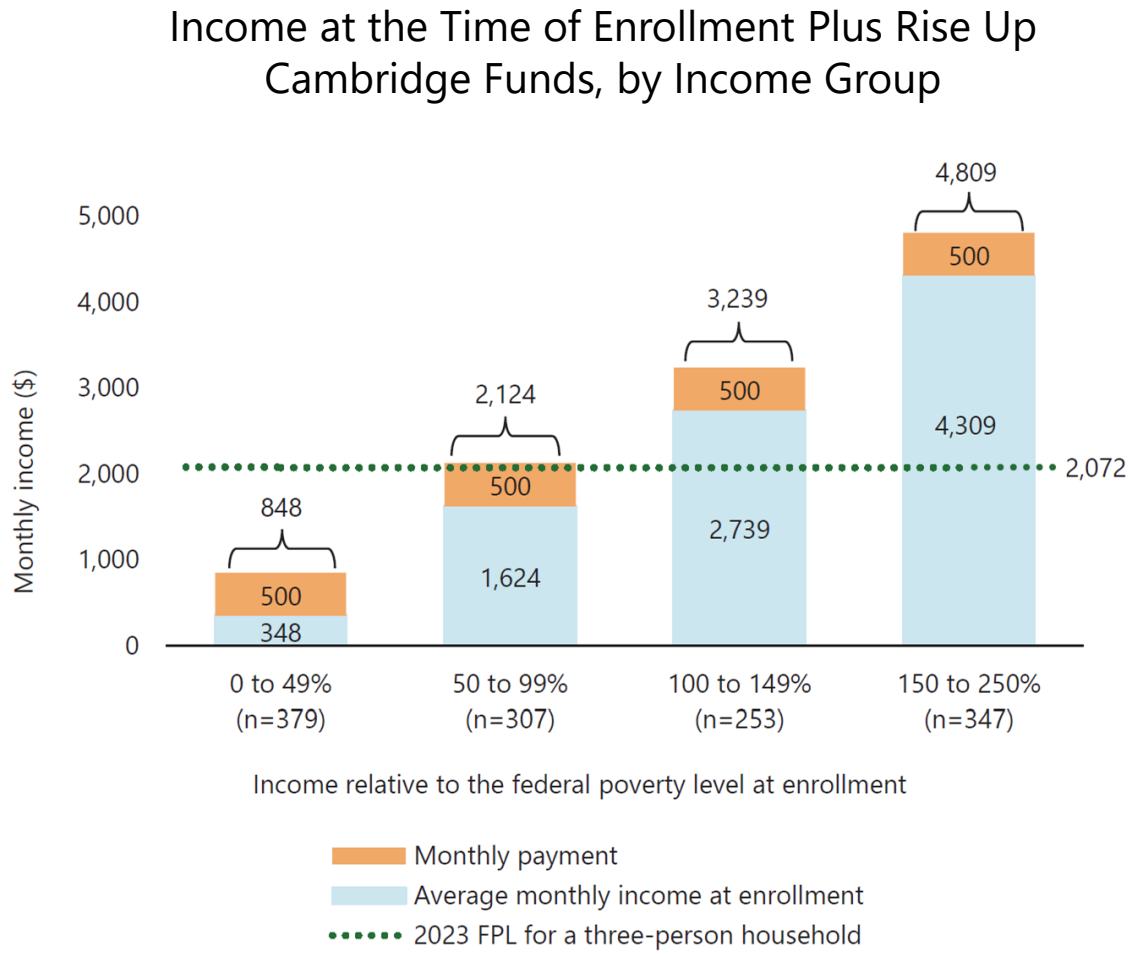
Study Sample

Participant Snapshot at Enrollment

- Female (79%)
- 42 years old
- Identifies as Black (49%)
- Single-parent households (64%)
- Working at least part time (72%)
- $23,650 (Median HH income)

- 1,286 study participants
- ~ 67% of all Rise Up participants
- Variety of family types, incomes, races/ethnicities
- Largely representative of all individuals enrolled in Rise Up, although may be some unobserved differences

Even with the addition of the Rise Up payments, many households remained below the federal poverty level



Outcomes

Families experienced meaningful financial relief during the program and made incremental progress that may contribute to future economic mobility, but some hardships remained.

Participant Perspectives

Reduced stress or anxiety

Ability to spend more time with family

Positive experiences and doing more things that they enjoy

Empowered by Rise Up and new opportunities opened to their families

Participants reported less stress or anxiety

Having a little bit more wiggle room each month to make sure that the basics are covered. . . . At one point, I was working a side job, like, grading essays and things. **That was kind of stressful, you know: staying up late grading these essays. I was able to stop doing that and actually get some sleep.** So little things like that, it just sort of took the pressure off.

Source: in-depth interview

Participants reported spending more time with family

I was blessed to be able to join Rise Up Cambridge, which was able to get my son out of this area [neighborhood]. We were able to go to movies. We were able to go to the pool at least once a month. . . . It's amazing when you can actually say, "You know what? **This month, I don't got to worry, and I can make plans to take my son to the movies and take him out to dinner."** It's a good feeling.

Source: in-depth interview

Comparison to other programs

	Streamlined application process
	Lack of restrictions enabled families to respond to changing needs
	Did not affect other benefits
	Lack of stigma
	Consistent payments once enrolled

Uses of payments

Families experienced meaningful financial relief during the program and made incremental progress towards future economic mobility, but some hardships remained.

Helped families meet basic needs

(85-93% of households)

Help for children in school, such as tutoring

(58% of households)

Pay for emergency expenses or unexpected bills

(75% of households)

Some larger material improvements (buying a vehicle, major appliance, housing)

(29% of households)

Savings or paying down debt

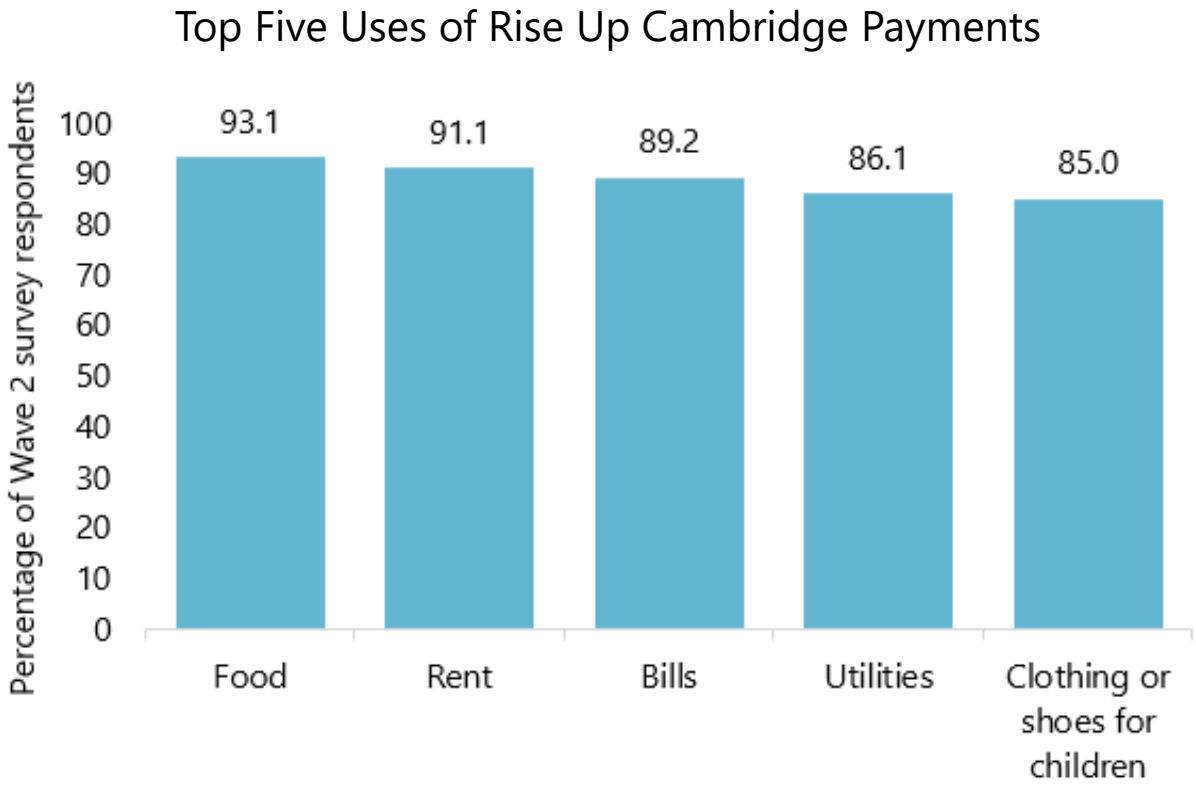
(58% and 71% of households, respectively)

Investing in education or training

(22% of households)

The five most common spending categories reported on the survey are related to basic needs: food, rent, bills, utilities, and clothing or shoes for children.

This pattern is consistent with experiences discussed in in-depth interviews and focus groups.



Rise Up families used funds to meet basic needs

With the food stamps, it is not enough to feed the kids. I was struggling with three boys and one girl. And now, I'm like, "You guys are eating me out of a [house]." So I'm like, "I can use that extra money to help out."

Source: focus group

Some families made larger material improvements

"Some money, **I use it for my driving classes, and after that I buy a car.** Because my health is no good. I can't walk too much because I have lupus and lung disease."

Source: in-depth interview

Economic Outcomes

Bolstered economic stability during the program, but few long-term changes.

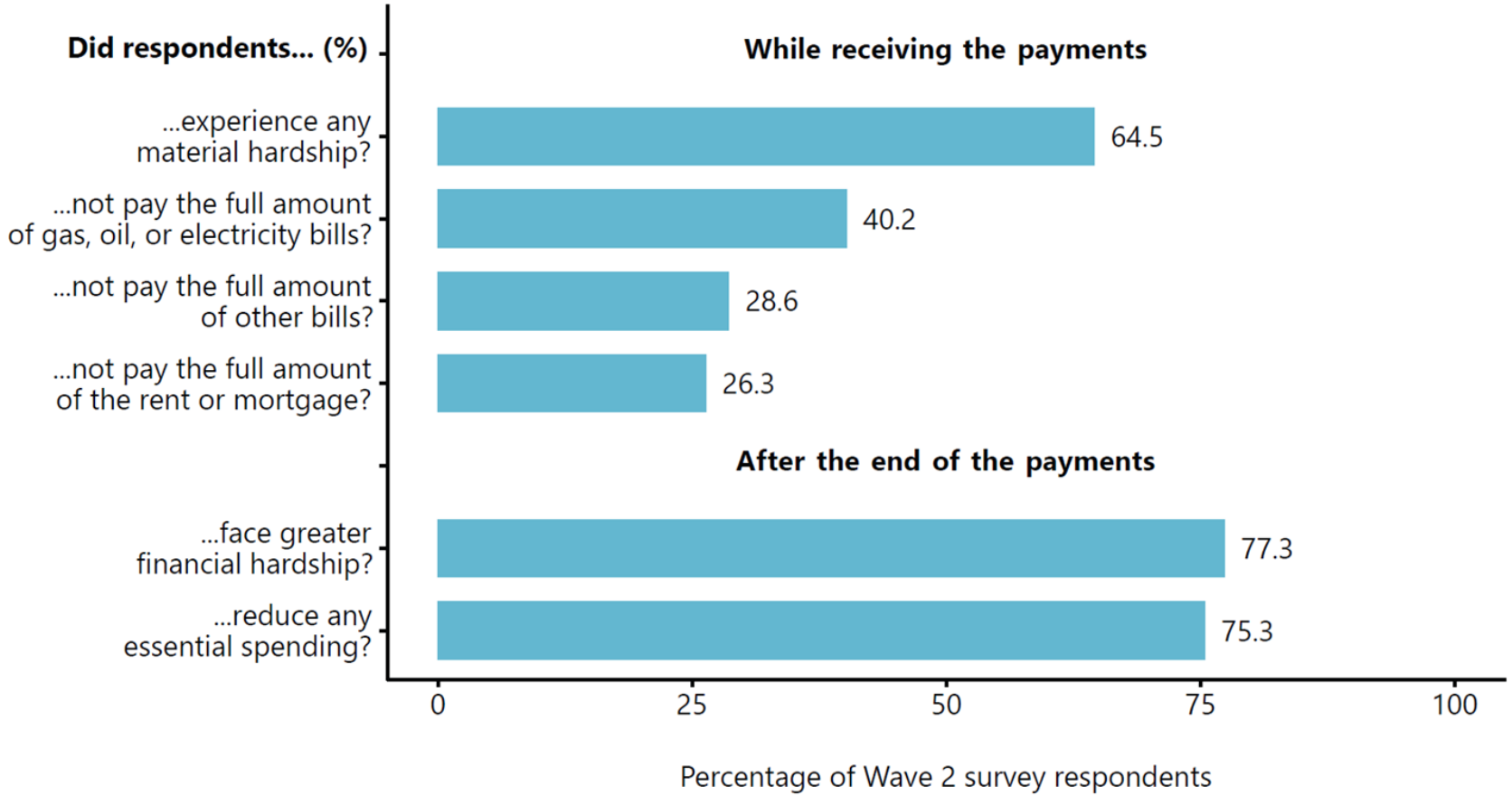
Participants reporting employment changes did not attribute them to the program

Hardships persisted during the program

Some savings, but rarely maintained after the program ended

Debt accumulation slowed or avoided, but share of households with debt and amount of debt remained high

Hardships persisted



Participants indicated that Rise Up made an important difference, but hardships persisted

My income was already not enough to cover the cost of living, and I was struggling as a single mom. The $500 monthly support really helped me manage my bills and cover my child's expenses. **At the very least, it allowed me to buy essential items for my family and keep up with some of my payments.**

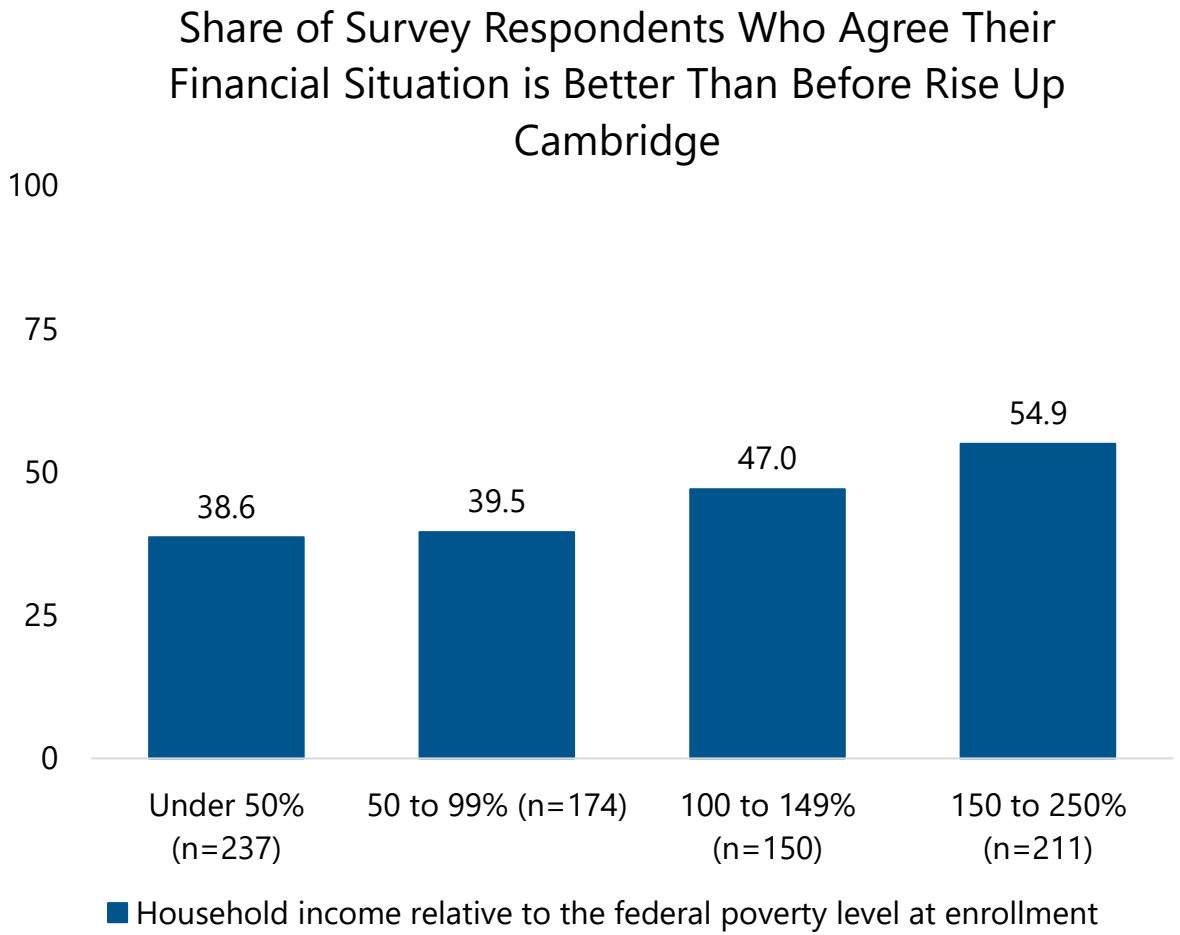
Source: in-depth interview

Variation across family groups and over time

- Higher-income level families fared better, and some differences existed across racial/ethnic groups.
- However, differences may reflect prior and ongoing challenges during the study period

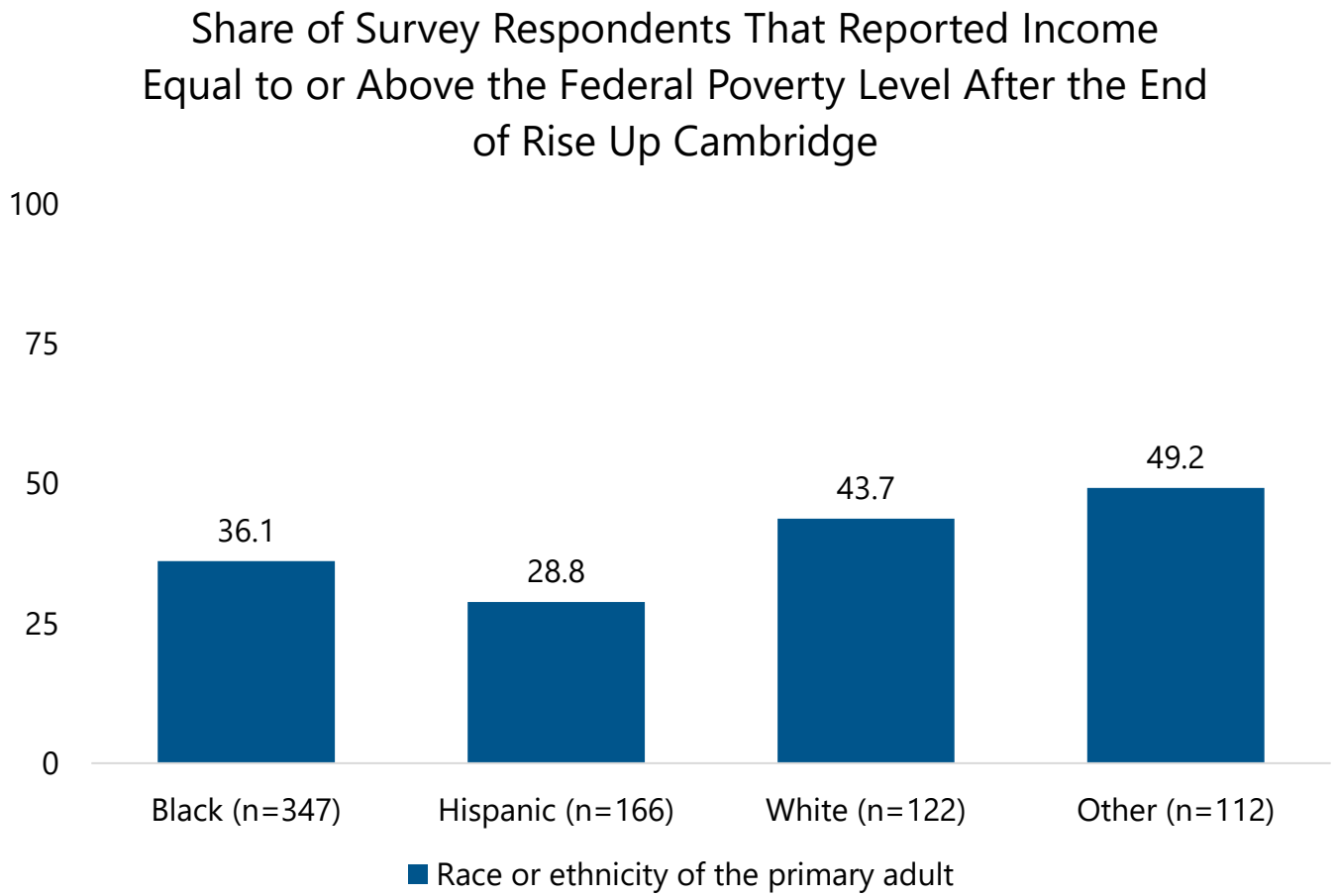
Higher-Income Families Fared Better

- Families with higher incomes were more likely to report stronger financial footing during Rise Up and afterwards
- Families with higher incomes were more likely to report feeling prepared for the end of Rise Up and that their financial situation was better after the program than before



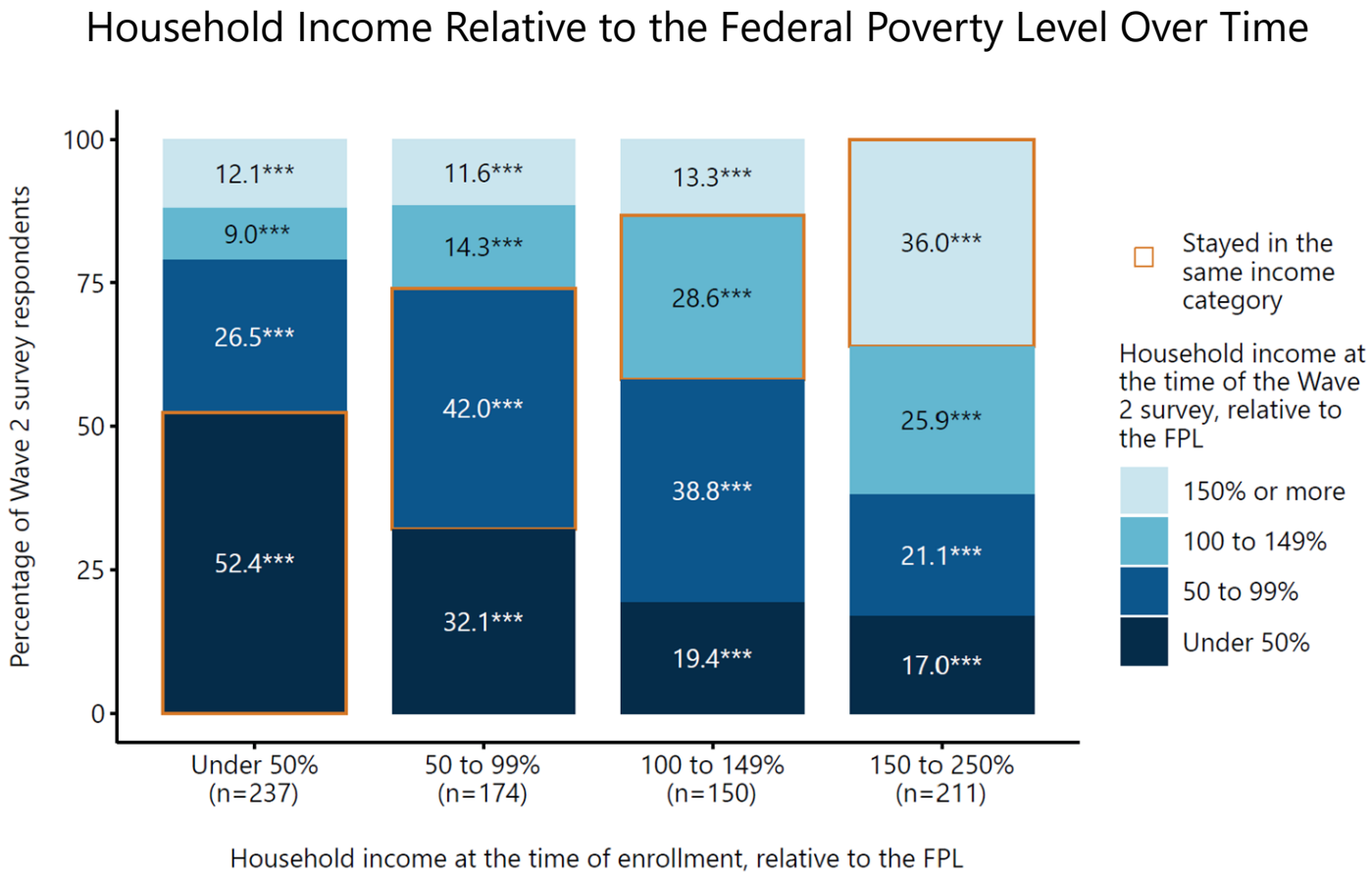
Some Evidence of Variation by Race and Ethnicity

- Hispanic families show higher levels of financial stress and debt and lower long-term savings
- Black families were more likely to report saving for future needs
- White families experienced larger stress increases after the program ended



Household income changes over time

- On average, household income did not significantly change over time
- The percentage of households with incomes below the federal poverty level increased over time
- Earnings may not keep up with rising costs and the income needed to stay above the federal poverty level



Participants experienced unstable jobs and earnings during the study period

I am in this place of, like, What am I going to do next? I've been a teacher for over 25 years. I was not given a contract [renewal] at my previous place of employment. . . . The transition for when I lost my job actually was made easier by the Rise Up grant because I had this breathing room. I could think about it. The job that I ended up taking [was] a job on a temporary basis. Like, it was only supposed to be a year commitment to help another woman who was at the [early childhood] center that I was working at.

Source: in-depth interview

Lessons from Implementation

Maximizing enrollment

1,927 families enrolled

Collaboration with nonprofit partners

Extensive outreach

- Public announcements, social media, flyers, and community events
- English, Spanish, Amharic, Haitian Creole

Web-based application and trained staff providing enrollment support

Protecting other benefits

Benefit waivers ensured that Rise Up families could maintain other benefits without penalties

The enrollment process was “smooth”

There was people there to help you if you needed it. It wasn’t like a stressed-out situation, so I think the whole process itself was good.

Source: in-depth interview

I first heard about the Rise Up Cambridge program through my kids’ school. The family liaison sent out flyers, and I thought it was an amazing opportunity. **The application process was easy for me since I’m tech-savvy and do everything on my phone.**

Source: in-depth interview

Rise Up did not affect eligibility for other benefits

The unfortunate part is if you do anything to supplement your income, they're gonna tie it to rent, and then they're gonna make it more. Even if it's a temporary [gig], you know, it's not consistent and you are just trying to find ways to supplement. **The benefit [of this program] is . . . being able to have that extra income and not have it affect me. That was actually big, a big thing.**

Source: focus group

IMPLICATIONS

Findings Overview

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Lessons from Rise Up



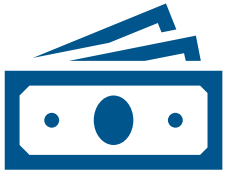
Consider additional factors, such as family size or other indicators of need

Higher income threshold



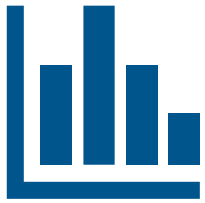
Longer program

(more than 18 months)

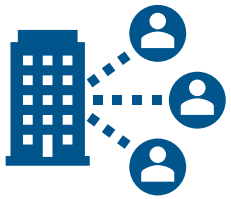


Lump sum payment rather than monthly

Lessons from Rise Up



Tier cash benefits relative to families' specific needs or circumstances



Supplement cash assistance with other supports to improve economic stability and foster mobility



Offer financial coaching multiple times throughout the cash program to engage more participants

“I feel like for so long I've been in survival mode. I'm just trying from paycheck to paycheck, and there's never enough and I'm always worried about what's gonna happen. **And what this 500 dollars a month has allowed me to do, for such a significant amount of time, it has allowed me to get out of survival mode.** Into a place where it's like, rebuilt. And not feel like there's a noose around my neck. I can put this here, and I can save this. And I can do this. And this is my budget, as opposed to just like [surviving].”

Source: in-depth interview

"I don't mean to hammer it home, but it's like **you can't save money out of poverty.** You can save, and save, and save. But it's like a cycle. And, well, the system isn't changing."

Source: focus group



THANK YOU

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APPENDIX

Data Collection Methods

Rise Up Application and Enrollment Data

Collected by AidKit

Two Online Surveys

In four languages.
Wave I: 409 (63% fielded sample)
Wave II: 772 (62% fielded sample)

Staff Interviews

One-hour interviews with five staff members; conducted in English and Spanish

Participant Interviews

A cohort of 26 families interviewed up to four times; conducted in English and Spanish

Participant Focus Groups

Seven focus groups over two rounds, representing a total of 33 participants

Storytelling

Audio journaling approach with six participants combining training, storyteller journals, and review of compiled ‘story’

Table A.1 Data Sources at a Glance

Data Source	Purpose	Sample Size
Baseline survey	Capture demographic and household characteristics at the time of enrollment in the program	1,286 primary adults that agreed to participate in the study
Wave 1 survey	Collect information about participants' early program experiences, use of payments, employment experiences, material hardship, health and well-being, and a range of other outcomes about one year into the program	409 respondents (or 63 percent of the fielded sample)
Wave 2 survey	Collect information on participants' experiences after the end of the program	772 respondents (or 62 percent of the fielded sample)
Staff interviews	Capture information on the design and implementation of Rise Up Cambridge	5 staff members

Table A.1 Data Sources at a Glance, cont'd

In-depth participant interviews	Capture information about the backgrounds and experiences of a panel of participants during and after Rise Up Cambridge; quarterly interviews enabled the research team to explore families' experiences over the course of the program and observe turning points in the interim months	26 participants during the initial round of interviews; as expected, there was some attrition over time[a]
Focus groups	Unpack preliminary findings from the survey and explore focus group members' experiences to identify similarities or differences	Round 1: Three focus groups comprising 9 total participants; Round 2: Four focus groups comprising 24 total participants
Storytelling narratives	Work with participants to develop narratives that center their voices and build counternarratives that may challenge perceptions of marginalized individuals[b]	6 participants

NOTES: [a]Subsequent rounds of interviews were done with 17, 19, and 16 participants. Of the original 26 panel members, 13 completed all four interviews.
[b]Wagaman, Obejero, and Gregory (2018).